

BEYOND THE CREST

Series Format Bible — Document 01

A Daytime Drama

Series Premiere (in-universe): Monday, January 5, 2026

Setting: Belmont Crest, a private gated community in affluent metro Atlanta, Georgia

First Family: The Donohues — Victor, Joan, Jasmine, Natasha & Alvin

0. Locked Canon (Story Rules)

These are the standing rules for every document, script, article, and post produced for *Beyond the Crest*. They do not change unless the showrunner changes them in writing.

- **Story frame year:** 2026 is our storytelling “present.” The story begins on the premiere date and moves forward in real time from there.
- **In-universe start date:** Monday, January 5, 2026 (Episode #0001).
- **One layer only:** The daytime soap opera *is* the story. There is no separate real-world or behind-the-scenes layer.
- **Storytelling formats:** Hollywood media and news media articles and headlines, social media, and the internet all exist **inside the story's universe** and cover the characters and events of the show. Alongside them runs heavy character-driven dialogue written in screenplay format.
- **Timeline:** Every event carries a date and time. Every character's age is calculated from a locked birthday on the date of the scene.
- **Tone:** Realistic to real life; creative, entertaining, dramatic, and original.
- **Cast:** Primarily African American ensemble, with a small number of non-Black characters.
- **Deliverables:** Every document is delivered as a PDF.
- **Continuity is paramount:** Nothing contradicts established canon. No character is nerfed — power, wealth, intellect, and status stay consistent unless the story earns a change on screen.

Premise

Set in **Belmont Crest**, a fictional gated community in the affluent Atlanta area, *Beyond the Crest* tells the story of a wealthy Black family in a posh, gated enclave. At the center is the **Donohue Family** — **Victor, Joan, Jasmine, Natasha, and Alvin** — a powerful and prestigious multigenerational family known as “**Black Royalty**.”

Character profiles, birthdays, and ages will be locked in Document 02 once the showrunner delivers the cast.

1. Episodes Per Year

RECOMMENDATION: 250 original episodes per broadcast year.

American daytime dramas air five days a week, Monday through Friday, all year with no summer hiatus. A calendar has 260–261 weekdays. Subtract about six network holidays (Thanksgiving, Christmas, New Year's Day, Memorial Day, Independence Day, Labor Day) and a few sports and breaking-news preemptions, and you land on roughly **250 new episodes**. That matches the output of long-running network soaps like *The Young and the Restless* and *General Hospital*.

Item	Count
Weekdays in a broadcast year	~261
Holiday dark days (encore or pre-empted)	~6

Item	Count
Sports / news pre-emptions (average)	~3–5
Original episodes	250
Weekly cadence	5 episodes (Mon–Fri)
Production pace	~5–6 episodes taped per week, ~6 weeks ahead of air

2. Season Numbering

RECOMMENDATION: Seasons follow the September–August network broadcast year. Episodes are numbered continuously for the life of the show and never reset.

Real daytime soaps don't reset to “Episode 1” each season. The on-screen and industry identity of an episode is its **cumulative episode number plus its air date** (for example, a long-running soap passing Episode #13,000). “Seasons” exist only as bookkeeping for the network's September–August broadcast year, which also governs the Daytime Emmy eligibility window.

Because *Beyond the Crest* premieres in January, it gets a realistic **shortened launch season** that wraps the week before Labor Day. After that, it runs on the standard broadcast calendar:

Season	Broadcast Window	Episodes	Episode #s
Season 1 (launch)	Mon, Jan 5, 2026 – Fri, Sep 4, 2026	170	#0001 – #0170
Season 2	Tue, Sep 8, 2026 – Fri, Sep 3, 2027	250	#0171 – #0420
Season 3	Tue, Sep 7, 2027 – early Sep 2028	250	#0421 – #0670
Each season after	Tuesday after Labor Day – Friday before Labor Day	250	+250 per season

Season 1 math: 175 weekdays from Jan 5 to Sep 4, 2026, minus Memorial Day (May 25) and Independence Day observed (Fri, Jul 3), minus about 3 sports/news pre-emptions = **170 episodes**.

Season 2 math: 259 weekdays from Sep 8, 2026 to Sep 3, 2027, minus Thanksgiving (Nov 26), Black Friday (Nov 27), Christmas (Fri, Dec 25), New Year's Day (Fri, Jan 1), Memorial Day (May 31), and Independence Day observed (Mon, Jul 5), minus about 3 pre-emptions = **250 episodes**.

Labor Day itself (Mon, Sep 7, 2026) is the realistic changeover point: it airs an encore, and the new season opens Tuesday.

How it's written on every document: BEYOND THE CREST – Episode #0001 – Season 1 – Monday, January 5, 2026

3. Serialized vs. Standalone Split

RECOMMENDATION: 90% serialized / 10% standalone-leaning. There are no true standalones: every episode moves continuity forward.

A daytime soap is the most serialized format in television. Stories braid across weeks, months, and years, and the audience expects yesterday's cliffhanger to be answered today. The 10% is reserved for **“event” episodes**: they have a self-contained shape but still advance at least one long-term arc and are fully canon. That works out to about **25 per broadcast year**, or roughly two a month:

- Holiday episodes (Thanksgiving at the Donohue estate, Christmas Eve gala, New Year's Eve).
- Flashback and origin episodes (how Victor built the empire; the Donohues in earlier decades).
- Character-spotlight or “bottle” episodes (a single location or a two-hander confrontation).
- Tentpole events: weddings, funerals, trials, galas, and milestone anniversaries (Episode #0250, #0500, #1000).

Continuity controls

- **Show Bible master timeline**: every scene logged with date, time, location, and characters present.
- **Age ledger**: birthdays locked; ages recomputed on the air date of each scene.
- **Story arc tracker**: long-term (6–18 months), mid-term (6–12 weeks), and short-term (1–3 weeks) arcs, cross-referenced by episode number.
- **Recap rule**: no scene contradicts a prior aired scene; any retcon must be explained on screen.

4. Genre, Subgenres, Rating & Runtime

Element	Recommendation
Primary genre	Daytime drama (soap opera), a continuing serial drama
Subgenres	Family dynasty saga • Wealth & power drama (“Black Royalty”) • Romance & romantic triangles • Corporate / boardroom intrigue • Legal & political drama • Mystery / suspense (whodunit arcs) • Melodrama
Rating	TV-14 , with content descriptors (D, L, S, V) applied per episode. That is today's standard for prime daytime dramas and allows adult stakes without prime-time explicitness.
Runtime	60-minute time slot , about 42 minutes of story content plus about 18 minutes of commercials and network promos
Format	Multi-camera, taped “as live” on soundstage sets with occasional location remotes (Atlanta exteriors, galas, weddings)
Timeslot	Weekdays, 12:30 PM or 1:00 PM ET / PT (network daytime block)

5. Episode Titling

RECOMMENDATION: No on-air episode titles. Each episode is identified by number and air date, with a one-line logline for listings. An internal working title is used in the writers' room only.

That's how real daytime soaps work. Episodes aren't titled on screen; networks, TV listings, and soap magazines identify them by **air date** and describe them with a short **logline**. Writers' rooms often keep informal working titles for tracking.

Field	Example
Official ID	Episode #0001 — Monday, January 5, 2026
Production code	BTC-S01-0001
Listing logline	Victor Donohue makes a stunning announcement at the family's New Year gala.
Internal working title (room only)	“The Crown on the Hill”

6. Script Length, Acts & Scenes

RECOMMENDATION: 85–95 pages (target 90), a Teaser plus 6 Acts, and 22–26 scenes (target 24) per episode.

Daytime scripts run much longer per minute than prime-time screenplays. The pages are almost all dialogue, written in the wider daytime script format, and an hour-long soap usually delivers about 2 pages per minute of screen time. Each episode braids **4–5 storylines** (A, B, C, D, and sometimes a runner), and each act ends on a hook before a commercial break. Act 6 ends on the episode's cliffhanger, the “Friday hook” being the biggest of the week.

Segment	Pages	Screen Time	Scenes	Purpose
Teaser (Cold Open)	5–6	~3 min	1–2	Pick up yesterday's cliffhanger; hook the audience
Main Title	—	~0:30	—	Opening credits & theme
Act 1	14–15	~6.5 min	4	Establish today's A/B/C stories
Act 2	14–15	~6.5 min	4	Complications; introduce D story
Act 3	14–15	~6.5 min	4	Midpoint turn / confrontation
Act 4	14–15	~6.5 min	4	Escalation; secrets surface
Act 5	13–14	~6.5 min	3–4	Collisions between storylines
Act 6	10–12	~6 min	3	Payoffs and the closing cliffhanger
TOTAL	~90	~42 min	~24	4–5 storylines braided

Each episode also carries: a title page (episode #, production code, air date, in-universe date/time span), a **cast list with ages as of the episode date**, a sets list, and a scene breakdown.

7. Multi-Platform Storytelling Toolkit

The soap opera is the story. Every article, headline, post, and web page below exists **inside the story's universe**, written by in-universe outlets, reporters, and users about in-universe people and events. Nothing here is real-world coverage of the show. Every item is timestamped and canon, and what the characters read, post, or see online can drive the plot.

Format	In-Universe Use
Screenplay scenes	Primary vehicle; character-driven dialogue
Hollywood media	Entertainment and celebrity press covering the Donohues and other characters: galas, red carpets, celebrity relationships, and any family ventures in film, music, fashion, or media
News media	Atlanta and national news, business and financial press on Donohue holdings, society pages, politics, crime and court coverage, legal filings
Social media	Characters' own posts, DMs, and livestreams; public reactions; trending hashtags about the family and the community

Format	In-Universe Use
Internet	Gossip blogs, message boards, anonymous leak sites, search results, viral videos, online reviews

8. Script Page Format Sample

A format illustration only, not canon dialogue. Canon scenes will be written once the cast is locked.

BEYOND THE CREST

EPISODE #0001 — PROD. BTC-S01-0001

AIR DATE: MONDAY, JANUARY 5, 2026

TEASER

1. INT. DONOHUE ESTATE — GRAND FOYER — NIGHT (MON 1/5/26, 8:02 PM)

Crystal. Marble. Old money that is *ours*. A string quartet plays beneath the sweeping staircase. GUESTS in black tie turn as a figure appears on the landing.

CHARACTER A

(low, to Character B)

He only comes down those stairs when he's about to change somebody's life.

CHARACTER B

Then let's hope it's not ours.

Glasses rise. The music stops. Every eye goes to the top of the stairs.

CUT TO: MAIN TITLE

9. Sweeps

RECOMMENDATION: Every sweeps period gets the show's biggest swings: weddings, returns, reveals, and deaths. Sweeps follow the Nielsen pattern of four weeks, Thursday through Wednesday, in February, May, July, and November.

Sweeps are the ratings periods that set ad rates for the months that follow, so daytime soaps have always scheduled their biggest stories inside them. Season 1 runs January to September, so it has three sweeps periods. November sweeps fall in Season 2.

Sweeps period	Dates	Season	Episodes
February Sweeps	Thu, Jan 29 – Wed, Feb 25, 2026	Season 1	#0019 – #0038 (20 eps)
May Sweeps	Thu, Apr 23 – Wed, May 20, 2026	Season 1	#0076 – #0095 (20 eps)
July Sweeps	Thu, Jun 25 – Wed, Jul 22, 2026	Season 1	#0120 – #0138 (19 eps)
November Sweeps	Thu, Oct 22 – Wed, Nov 18, 2026	Season 2	Season 2
February Sweeps	Thu, Jan 28 – Wed, Feb 24, 2027	Season 2	Season 2
May Sweeps	Thu, Apr 22 – Wed, May 19, 2027	Season 2	Season 2
July Sweeps	Thu, Jun 24 – Wed, Jul 21, 2027	Season 2	Season 2

Sweeps rules for the writers' room

- Each sweeps period opens on a major turn and closes on a cliffhanger.
- At least one tentpole event episode lands inside every sweeps period.
- Returns, new cast arrivals, and paternity or identity reveals are held for sweeps whenever the story calendar allows.
- Events tied to real dates (awards shows, holidays, birthdays) stay on their real dates even when they fall just outside sweeps.